NEUROSCIENCE AT WORK

The Leading Brain

Powerful Science-Based Strategies for Achieving Peak Performance

Friederike Fabritius and Hans W. Hagemann · 2017

A neuropsychologist and a leadership consultant translate brain science into practical strategies for performing at your best, managing emotions, building habits and leading teams.[1,2,3]

WHY READ IT

- Brain science made practical for everyday work[2,4]
- Concrete techniques for stress, focus and habits[4]
- A fresh look at what makes teams work well together[3,4]

GET THE BOOK



The Leading Brain by Friederike Fabritius and Hans W. Hagemann
TarcherPerigee (Penguin Random House), 2017. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *The Leading Brain* by Friederike Fabritius and Hans W. Hagemann. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Find your sweet spot

You do your best work at a moderate level of arousal: too little and you're bored, too much and you panic. This curve goes back to Yerkes and Dodson in 1908. The authors show how to tune the task, the setting or the stakes so you stay in the zone where focus, and sometimes flow, come naturally.[3,4,5,10]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Name the feeling**
   Labelling an emotion helps restore control. Suppressing it competes with your thinking.[3,7,9]

2. **Habits slip in small**
   A large share of daily behavior runs on habit. Small, low-threat steps help new habits form without resistance.[4,8]

3. **Mix your team**
   Drawing on Helen Fisher's research, the authors describe four temperaments. Strong teams combine them.[4,11]

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THE FRAMEWORK

Peak · Change · Teams[1,6]

The book's three parts, each with three chapters.[6]

1 Reach your peak

Sweet spot, emotions, focus

Performance depends on a balance of brain chemicals the authors call a neurococktail.[2,12]

Try: Use STOP: Stop, Take a breath, Observe, Proceed.[4]

2 Change your brain

Habits, intuition, learning

Build habits in small steps, and give weight to intuition in complex decisions.[4,8]

Try: Write down a goal that matters to you emotionally.[4]

3 Build dream teams

Diversity, trust, the future

Explorer, Builder, Director and Negotiator temperaments, plus trust that keeps people in a reward state rather than a threat state.[3,4,11]

Try: Social pain registers much like physical pain.[3,8]

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

The sweet-spot audit

Based on the book's approach to peak performance.[4]

1. List your typical week's activities.
2. Tag each: bored, stressed, or top of your game.
3. Turn bored tasks up with challenge or a deadline.
4. Turn stressful tasks down by breaking them up or getting support.

STOP

A short reset the authors recommend.[4]

1. Stop what you're doing.
2. Take a breath.
3. Observe your thoughts, feelings and body.
4. Proceed, on purpose.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Rate today's main task from 1 (bored) to 10 (overwhelmed).
2. Under 4, add a challenge. Over 7, break it into steps.
3. Use STOP before one stressful moment each day.
4. Each night, write three things you're grateful for, and protect your sleep.

REFLECT

When were you last at the top of your game, and what made it possible?

Which temperament is missing from your team?

Try it in Sedi: Break an overwhelming task into small steps as a project in Timely's Planning view.

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READ THE BOOK

🧠 The Leading Brain

Friederike Fabritius and Hans W. Hagemann · TarcherPerigee (Penguin Random House) · 2017

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Friederike Fabritius and Hans W. Hagemann or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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